Environment and climate

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: The climate challenge: can the planet be saved? (194 words)

Scientists agree that **global warming** is the defining problem of our age. Every year, burning **fossil fuels** adds more **greenhouse gas** to the atmosphere, and the **emissions** from factories, planes and cars show few signs of falling fast enough. Individuals are urged to reduce their **carbon footprint**, but critics point out that policy, not personal choice, will decide the outcome.

The effects are already visible. Longer periods of **drought** threaten harvests, while **deforestation** destroys the **habitat** of countless animals and reduces **biodiversity**. Many species are now **endangered**, and some have already become **extinct**. A damaged **ecosystem** can **collapse** with surprising speed, as the loss of coral reefs has shown.

Hope lies in **renewable** energy and in more **sustainable** ways of living. Cities are building **eco-friendly** transport networks, households are learning to **recycle** more, and the amount of waste going to **landfill** is slowly falling. Organizations devoted to **conservation** work to protect wild places, and campaigns **raise awareness** of **pollution** and plastic waste. Yet progress is uneven. Rich countries can afford new technology; poorer ones **bear the brunt of** the damage they did little to cause. The challenge is therefore as much about fairness as about science.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
collapse	fall apart completely
bear the brunt of	suffer the worst of

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
global warming	n	the rise of Earth's temperature	*Global warming is melting the polar ice.*
greenhouse gas	n	gas that traps heat in the air	*Cars release greenhouse gases.*
carbon footprint	n	the carbon dioxide caused by a person or group	*We should reduce our carbon footprint.*
renewable	adj	able to be used again naturally	*Solar and wind are renewable energy sources.*
fossil fuels	n	coal, oil and gas	*Fossil fuels cause most air pollution.*
deforestation	n	the cutting down of forests	*Deforestation threatens many species.*

biodiversity	n	the variety of living things	*Biodiversity is falling in tropical regions.*
endangered	adj	at risk of disappearing	*Tigers are an endangered species.*
sustainable	adj	able to continue without damaging nature	*Sustainable farming protects the soil.*
pollution	n	harmful substances in the environment	*Air pollution is a danger in big cities.*
landfill	n	a place where rubbish is buried	*Plastic waste fills landfill sites.*
recycle	v	to process used things to make new ones	*Many households now recycle glass and paper.*
drought	n	a long period with no rain	*The drought destroyed the harvest.*
habitat	n	the natural home of a plant or animal	*Roads destroy the habitats of wild animals.*
emissions	n	gases sent into the air	*The new law cuts emissions from factories.*
conservation	n	protecting nature	*Conservation projects save rare animals.*
ecosystem	n	a community of living things and their environment	*Plastic damages the ocean ecosystem.*
extinct	adj	no longer existing	*Dinosaurs became extinct millions of years ago.*
eco-friendly	adj	not harmful to the environment	*Eco-friendly products are becoming popular.*
raise awareness	v	to make people notice an issue	*Campaigns raise awareness of plastic waste.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
digital divide	n	the gap between people with and without technology
artificial intelligence	n	computer systems that copy human thinking
automation	n	using machines instead of workers
cyberbullying	n	bullying through the internet
privacy	n	freedom from being watched or disturbed
addictive	adj	hard to stop using
innovation	n	a new idea or method
obsolete	adj	no longer used because something better exists
cutting-edge	adj	the most advanced
user-friendly	adj	easy to use

Practice: fill the gaps

extinct · endangered · greenhouse gas · global warming · landfill · raise awareness · renewable · deforestation

1. Dinosaurs became _____ millions of years ago.
2. Tigers are an _____ species.
3. Cars release _____.
4. _____ is melting the polar ice.
5. Plastic waste fills _____ sites.
6. Campaigns _____ of plastic waste.
7. Solar and wind are _____ energy sources.
8. _____ threatens many species.

More words on this topic **(not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)**

acid rain (n): rain made harmful by pollution
air quality (n): how clean or polluted the air is
carbon neutral (adj): adding no net carbon to the air
climate change (n): long-term change in weather patterns
composting (n): turning plant waste into fertilizer
disposable (adj): made to be thrown away after use
energy-efficient (adj): using little energy
environmentalist (n): a person who works to protect nature
geothermal (adj): using heat from inside the Earth
global heating (n): another term for rising temperature
ice cap (n): a large area of permanent ice
nuclear power (n): energy from atoms
oil spill (n): oil escaping into the sea
ozone layer (n): a layer of gas that protects the Earth
over-fishing (n): catching too many fish
plastic waste (n): used plastic that is thrown away
poaching (n): illegal hunting of animals
reforestation (n): planting trees again
rubbish (n): waste
single-use (adj): used once and thrown away
smog (n): polluted air in cities
solar panel (n): a device that turns sunlight into power
toxic (adj): poisonous
wind farm (n): a group of wind turbines
wildlife (n): wild animals and plants
water shortage (n): not enough water
natural resources (n): materials such as water and coal
tackle (v): to deal with a problem
phase out (v): to stop using gradually
carbon tax (n): a charge on carbon emissions

Topic kit: what to know about this topic

Writing Task 2 questions you may meet

1. Some people say individuals should reduce their carbon footprint; others say only governments can solve environmental problems. Discuss both views.
2. Plastic waste is damaging the oceans. What are the causes and what solutions can you suggest?
3. Do the benefits of tourism outweigh its damage to the environment?
4. Animals and plants are disappearing. Is it important to protect endangered species? To what extent do you agree?

Ideas you can use in essays and in speaking

- **For / good:** Governments can make laws, tax pollution and fund renewable energy on a scale no individual can match.
- **Against / bad:** Citizens' daily choices, such as recycling and using less plastic, add up and change companies' behavior.
- **For / good:** Renewable energy creates jobs and reduces long-term costs.
- **Against / bad:** Building wind and solar farms can be expensive and damage local habitats.
- **For / good:** Protecting biodiversity keeps ecosystems healthy, which protects food and water.
- **Against / bad:** Poor countries may struggle to protect wildlife while fighting poverty.

Speaking

Part 1

- Is your area clean?
- Do you recycle at home?
- What kind of weather do you like?
- Do you like spending time in nature?
- Have you ever joined an environmental activity?

Part 3

- Who should be responsible for protecting the environment?
- Why do some people ignore environmental problems?
- Will the climate be better or worse in 50 years?
- Should plastic bags be banned?

Part 2 cue card. Describe a place in nature you enjoyed visiting. You should say: where it is, when you went, what you did there, and explain why it was special.

Answers

1. extinct (extinct)
2. endangered (endangered)
3. greenhouse gases (greenhouse gas)
4. Global warming (global warming)
5. landfill (landfill)
6. raise awareness (raise awareness)
7. renewable (renewable)
8. Deforestation (deforestation)